and dance troupes. Marshalling all these diverse elements coming from different places in the correct sequence at Vijay Chowk, and releasing them in sequence at precisely the right time and with the same precise gap between various contingents. Various elements also go at different speeds, the mechanized columns and vehicles are faster than the marching contingents. The camel-borne contingent has its own pace altogether. All these variables have to be kept in mind, so that irrespective of what time the contingents start from Vijay Chowk, they must cross the saluting dais at the appointed minute. Communication arrangements have to be foolproof and the public address system par excellence. Coordination also has to be done with the commentators, to ensure that the correct script is read out at the right time, just as the contingent or troupe is approaching and passing by the saluting dais. Recovery arrangements have to be put in place just in case some vehicle breaks down, so that it can be whisked away without upsetting the flow of the parade. Coordinating the fly-past is an even more complex and gut-wrenching exercise. All this is quite similar to the backstage activities that the audience never realizes or gets to see.

The GOC Delhi Area leads the Parade, i.e., he is in the first Gypsy vehicle that rolls down Kartavya Path and gives the salute to the President of India and Commander-in-Chief of the Armed Forces on behalf of the entire country. It is a very emotional and supercharged moment. All my close family members were in the audience—Veena, Isha and Amala (who had come down from Singapore), Simon and other friends and relatives. It was an emotional moment for them too, to see their father as the torchbearer of the hopes and aspirations of an entire nation. Standing erect in the first vehicle, looking neither left nor right, one is acutely conscious that the eyes of the entire nation are on you. It is an unforgettable experience.

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